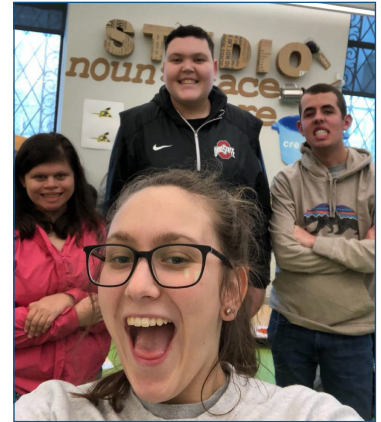


By Mallory Workman and Jessie Green

Introduction

To create inclusive campuses, the use of peer mentors is integral in providing supports to students with intellectual disability (ID). Using this guide will provide institutions of higher education (IHEs) a model of how to support students with ID in academic and social settings. Strategies for recruitment, retention, and training of peer mentors are offered.

Crisp and Cruz (2009) published a literature review of mentoring which describes it as a collaborative relationship between two people that can be formal or informal, short-term or long-term, and can focus on “the growth and accomplishment of an individual, assisting in professional and career development, role modeling, psychological support, and the development of personal and reciprocal relationships” (p. 528).



Roles and Responsibilities

Peer mentors can provide a wide variety of encouragement both in and outside the classroom. These can include academic, social, and independent-living supports to aid in the success of students in an inclusive college setting.

Peer supports can be identified through many terms by a program, including mentors, coaches (educational/job/life), allies (academic/social), volunteers, assistants, interns, guides, and more. Their roles can include health and wellness coaching (workout buddies/meal prep coaches), mobility training, academic supports, job and career readiness coaching, and support with campus engagement and involvement.

The table below illustrates sample roles for a peer mentor program and the expectations that correspond with each role:

Educational Coach	Tutor	Social Coach
ROLE DEFINITION: The educational coach provides any in-class supports that a student might need in their inclusive university course. Responsibilities: • Attends inclusive university course to provide any requested in-class supports. • Assists in “leveling the playing field” for the student by facilitating individualized accommodations and modifications. • Provides supports that may include: » Note-taking » Self-advocacy » Communication support with peers » Dissemination of information about course content to the student in away appropriate for the student’s learning needs » Behavior modeling » Acquisition of skills • Communicates with others to help support student’s needs.	ROLE DEFINITION: The tutor provides any outside-of-class supports for students related to their inclusive university course. Responsibilities: • Staffs the program’s academic center. • Provides assistance and support with any outside-of-class work. • Assists students with organizational and time management skills. • Completes assignments with (not for) students. • Facilitates down-time professional development activities for the students, such as: » Practicing interview questions » Filling out job applications » Job and career research	ROLE DEFINITION: The social coach supports students in the social and campus membership events sponsored by the program and/or the university. Responsibilities: • Attends social activities on campus with students. • Models appropriate behaviors and etiquette in social settings. • Provides supports such as: » Tipping and money management » Making healthy choices when out to eat » Situation-specific etiquette

Recruitment

RECRUITMENT STRATEGIES

When addressing the recruitment of peer mentors, the issues of quality AND quantity need to be considered. It is vital for programs to find a “sweet spot” for the number of peer mentors before beginning recruitment. Finding a good mentor-to-student ratio helps to avoid having a surplus of mentors with not enough students to support, in addition to avoiding a shortage of mentors, which leaves the current mentors feeling spread too thin. Typically, we find that a 2:1 or a 3:1 ratio works best depending on the size of the program and the intensity of supports.

Programs must consider how they will compensate peer mentors, if at all. Compensating peer mentors via course credit or for pay can be used as a recruitment strategy and also helps to raise accountability expectations. However, not all programs will have the resources to provide compensation.

RECRUITMENT METHODS

Word of mouth can be one of the most powerful recruitment techniques for peer mentors. Current and former peer mentors share their experiences with friends, roommates, classmates, and the organizations they are involved with to recruit additional peer mentors for the program. In addition, the following outlets for recruitment have also been found to be successful:

- » Sending information about the opportunity to the faculty and staff advisors of specific academic programs, such as education, special education, disability studies, health and rehabilitation sciences, pre-physical therapy, pre-occupational therapy, psychology, pre-medical, human development and family science, etc. Collaborating with faculty and staff from these departments might allow for program involvement to count towards required practicum hours or other work experience for peer mentors.
- » Contacting the leaders of relevant student organizations to disseminate the information (sororities, fraternities, class honoraries, organizations focused on inclusion, teaching, access to education, disability rights, etc.).
- » Contacting the residential advisors for living-learning communities, specifically those focused on higher education, policy and advocacy, leadership, teaching, service, etc.

Here is an example of recruitment language that could be sent out to various departments:

The (name of program) offers individuals ages 18 and older with intellectual and developmental disabilities a unique opportunity to engage in academic coursework, work experiences, independent living skills, and participation in campus and community organizations, as well as social activities and events.

We are looking for dedicated individuals to serve as tutors, educational coaches, and social coaches, and to engage in an internship course during (semester and year) with our students.

Please contact (staff member's name that coordinates mentors) at (email) for more information, or fill out the application [here](#) (add program or peer mentor application link).



Application and Interview Process

Professionalizing the process for onboarding peer mentors, even as a volunteer or for course credit, will help to set high expectations. Customizing the application and interview questions can support this goal.

Peer Mentor Application	Peer Mentor Interview Questions
What is your major/minor?	How did you hear about the program?
What peer mentoring position (based on those available within the program) are you interested in, and why?	What mentoring experiences have you had in the past, including those working with individuals with disabilities?
How many hours are you willing to commit to the program per week?	Why do you want to begin working with transition-age students with disabilities?
What is your weekly availability (taking into account class and work schedules)?	Which peer mentoring position are you interested in, and why?
Please share your previous or current employment and/or volunteer experiences.	What supports will you need to have a successful peer mentoring experience?
Have you had any experiences that would help you to understand the needs of transition-age youth with disabilities? If so, please describe.	Situational question, including the following scenarios: • You are at a social event and you notice a student is off to the side, not engaging in the event. What would you do? • You are in the academic center and a student is on their phone, playing games. What would you do to motivate this student to focus on class work? • You are an educational coach in a class and there is a group activity. The student you are assigned to is receiving natural supports from other students in the class and is working well in the group independently. What would you do?
Please provide (#) personal/professional references who can speak to your strengths as a peer mentor.	



Training

The activities and descriptions below can help your program get started with training peer mentors. For more resources, visit the Think College website.

Activity	Description
In-person Training	Meet at the beginning of the semester for new peer mentors (or peer mentors who change to a new role). Topics can include: • Introduction to Think College and transition programs • Introduction to the IHE's specific program • Introduction to ID • Roles and responsibilities of peer mentors • Panel of returning peer mentors • Scenario and situational-based discussions
Meet and Greet Event	Coordinate a meet and greet so students can get to know the peer mentors they will be working with. This event is for all peer mentors and students. Activities could include: • Ice cream social or hot chocolate social (food) • Ice breaker activities • Opportunities for peer mentors and students with ID to exchange contact information
Webinars	Conduct webinars to provide an opportunity for peer mentors to connect with program staff. Webinars can be used to: • Share updates and announcements • Ask questions • Share important deadlines and things to remember • Review policy and procedures
Online Peer Mentor Modules	Provide online modules for peer mentors that could include quizzes on topics such as: • Who are students with ID? • College and the specific postsecondary program • Roles, rights, and responsibilities of the student with ID • Roles, rights, and responsibilities of the peer mentor • Technology to support students with ID • Understanding confidentiality • Goal-setting with students with ID
Advanced Training	Provide articles related to postsecondary education programs in these areas: • Academic access and supports • Career development • Social engagement • Intellectual disability • Legal issues • Higher Education Opportunity Act • Interagency collaboration
Peer Mentor Handbook	• Develop a handbook to describe program policies and procedures, staff contact information, and roles and responsibilities of students with ID, peer mentors, and staff.

Considerations for Setting Up a Peer Mentoring System

Here are just a few of the questions to consider:

- » Will the program pay peer mentors, provide course credit, or just use volunteers?
- » How can you use the existing resources on your campus?
- » Who will oversee the peer mentors?
- » Who will be responsible for scheduling peer mentors?
- » What technology can be used to coordinate peer mentor schedules?
 - *When to Work?*
 - *Google Forms/Calendar?*
 - *Doodle?*
- » How will students and/or peer mentors access program staff after hours if needed?
- » How will peer mentors communicate with each other? With the staff advisor? With the students with ID?
- » What level of support do the peer mentors provide to each student?
- » What training methods and materials will you disseminate to peer mentors? (e.g., peer mentor handbook, in-person training, online modules, webinars, etc.)
- » What is the process to address any issues that arise between peer mentors and students with ID?
- » What tools will you offer to help peer mentors and students with ID extend their friendships after the end of the program?

Having a strong peer mentor program benefits not only students in your program, but also the mentors and the larger campus. Through involvement with postsecondary programs for students with ID, peer mentors are able to build practical skills they can take into future careers. Likewise, the students they work with gain skills while building natural friendships along the way.

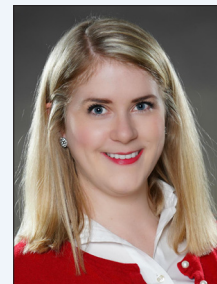


Reference

Crisp, G., & Cruz, I. (2009). Mentoring college students: A critical review of the literature between 1990 and 2007. *Research in Higher Education*, 50(6), 525–545.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

MALLORY WORKMAN is the academic advisor and head of volunteer recruitment for The Ohio State University TOPS Program. Mallory has been with the TOPS for nearly seven years, having served as a peer mentor for the program during her undergraduate career.



JESSIE GREEN is the manager of The Ohio State University TOPS program. Previously, Jessie was a classroom teacher. She is currently working on her PhD in educational policy.



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